

MINIMUM NUMBER 2: THINK AHEAD AND AVOID PROBLEMS

The Lord taught His disciples, "For which one of you, when he wants to build a tower, does not first sit down and calculate the cost, to see if he has enough to complete it?" (Luke 14:28) Too often, young couples put off planning until they're in trouble. Then it's usually too late, except for "crisis" planning.

I recommend that you write down your goals and objectives before you're married, including a first year's budget. Then every year, plan to go away somewhere together for at least one day just to update your budget and evaluate your goals. Look back at the previous year and determine if you're still on track with your goals. If you will make this a priority, it will be the best investment of time you'll ever make.

Obviously, your minimum goal should be to avoid financial bondage through debt. This doesn't mean you can't borrow to buy anything. But borrowing to buy consumables such as gifts, vacations, even cars, will quickly put a family in bondage. Buying something on credit that you can't afford doesn't avoid the decision that you shouldn't buy it; credit only delays the consequences and makes them worse.

I can remember at Christmas seeing a large billboard produced by a credit card company that said, "Go ahead and do it. You owe it to yourself." Let me assure you, they didn't mean that. What they really meant was, "Go ahead and do it, and you'll owe it to us at 21 percent per year."

Remember minimum number 2: think ahead.

MINIMUM NUMBER 3: KEEP GOOD RECORDS

In counseling young couples, I discovered that less than 2 out of 10 knew how to balance a checkbook. Solomon wrote, "By wisdom a house is built, and by understanding it is established; and by knowledge the rooms are filled with all precious and pleasant riches" (Proverbs 24:3-4). It is impossible to have your finances under control without understanding the basics of good bookkeeping. Very few young couples understand how to evaluate life insurance or how much to spend on housing or